

MELANCHOLIC FUGUE:
Jhumpa Lahiri



LIFE IS ELSEWHERE

Jhumpa Lahiri's relentlessly cheerless expatriate Bengalis are caught between home and the world, the past and the future



UNACCUSTOMED EARTH
by JHUMPA LAHIRI
Random House
Price: Rs 450
Pages: 352

■ **By Brinda Bose**

Perhaps Jhumpa Lahiri's legacy as a writer will put Bengali-American fiction firmly on the world literary map. *Unaccustomed Earth*, her second collection of short stories with a title inspired by a Hawthorne novel, retreads accustomed Lahiri territory, for here, Ms Bong Connection returns to the familiar fever and fret of NRI lives and loves, realised or apprehended.

Having long been a diasporic Bengali of sorts, as well as a Boston graduate student once (like the writer), I must admit, though, that I am astonished at how relentlessly cheerless Lahiri's expatriate Bengalis are. Whatever happened to the famed Bengali *joie de vivre* that inspires zesty

Rabindra-sangeet when it rains even in chilly New England, and the notoriously wry wit that is the hallmark of the *bangali adda* in Bengal, Boston and beyond? Lahiri's chronicling of the stretching and straining between incohesive summer holidays in Calcutta and emotionally-ragged existences on adopted alien soil, is continually bathed in the wretchedness of being caught between homes and worlds, memories and desires, parents and selves, roots and routes, pasts and futures.

Unaccustomed Earth, consisting of five long stories and a short novella in three chapters, is a predictable variation on Lahiri's now-patented melancholic fugue on the Bengali-American diaspora. That said, one must concede its inexplicable, inexorable power to entice you into the exquisite minutiae of bounded Bengali lives scattered mainly around the American north-east. In the title story, Ruma is surprised by an inchoate tenderness for her recently-widowed father on his

visit to her married home in Seattle, only to discover with some dismay after his departure that he is now secretly pursuing a romantic relationship with a woman he met on his travels—a dismay she cannot explain or discard.

In 'Hell-Heaven', Lahiri chronicles a bloodless Bengali marriage between a research-obsessed professor and his neglected, bored housewife, until she springs to sudden life with the forbidden flaring of desire for a homesick male graduate student who partakes of her passionately-prepared meals and induces in her other cravings and hungers, *a la* Tagore/Ray's *Charulata*. There are other engrossing tales of occidental mixed marriages, alcoholic brothers and lovely Bengali girls who are both loved and abused with abandon. There is no exultation, however, in these stories, no intellectual depths to plumb, not a single trace of levity.

Lahiri is at her soaring, liberated best when she surfaces for a brief and tempestuous love among the ruins of Rome, in a three-part novella titled simply 'Hema and Kaushik', which wraps up the collection triumphantly. It is as if the writer, when she finally dares to unmoor herself from the safety, the boredom and the horror of what she knows most intimately, discovers the beauty of the unaccustomed earth outside of her familiar zone, in a peculiar, if shockingly logical, irony. Lahiri has claimed Marquez as one of her inspirations, but there is a touch of Kundera here instead, which may be traced in the philosophical legacy of *The Unbearable Lightness of Being*, fleetingly reconstructed by Lahiri in the final chapter of the novella: that the most searing of human passions cannot ultimately be borne, and can only be tsunami-swept into the sea.

And in the poignancy of this novella's storyline, its admirably taut linguistic control, its experimentation with narrative voices and its departure from North American shores, it may be that Lahiri has finally come into her own—a territory fearful because it is unknown yet, and prescient for the very same reason. Let Lahiri now allow herself to be thus tsunami-swept into further uncharted waters, and when she washes ashore at some other unaccustomed piece of earth, there will surely be fresh roots that clutch. ■